

CHAPTER 3 — THE WEEPING FOREST

After the Night Stalker's death, Nathanos Thornwell carried the wounded Raphael Marchand through the snow toward the waiting royal carrier. Raphael's strength was fading with every step, and though he still tried to answer Nathanos with faint humor, the blood at his mouth and the wound beneath his armor made it clear that the strike had damaged him deeply.

Inside the carrier, Nathanos lit the candles with his inner flame and tended to Raphael as carefully as he could. He gave him water, cleaned the blood from his face, and prepared to remove his armor so he could see the wound properly. But when Nathanos tried to lift the chest plate, Raphael screamed in agony. The flesh, cloth, and armor had fused together where Nathanos's flame had sealed the wound in the snow.

With no other choice, Nathanos heated the armor with the Searing Flame and tore it free in one terrible motion. The pain nearly broke Raphael, but the wound remained closed enough for him to survive. Nathanos removed the last fragments of metal and cloth, cleaned the injury, cut away Raphael's ruined clothing, dressed him in spare clothes, and wrapped him in a blanket.

Shaken by what his own flame had done while trying to save him, Nathanos held Raphael's hand and begged him not to die. He promised to drive the carrier back to Kalluth and check on him whenever he could. Before leaving, Nathanos threw the ruined chest plate out into the snow so Raphael would not have to see or smell what had been torn from him.

Outside, Nathanos freed the horses of the fallen soldiers, refusing to leave them tied in the cold. Then he climbed onto the driver's bench, took the reins, and began the long road back to Kalluth, carrying Raphael away from the Dark Forest with only one thought left to hold onto: they were going home.

Far to the southeast—closer to the borderlands where Bloodmoon influence stains the map—
Velldendar changes its voice.

Here, the war between Kalluth and the Bloodmoon tribe hasn't reached yet—not with marching banners or burning villages. There are no towns to shelter behind, no warm hearths hidden beyond the next ridge—only mountains, endless and cold, piling into the horizon like a world made of stone. Snow falls cleaner in this part of Velldénar, and the wind cuts sharper, as if it has fewer trees to soften it. The forest thins into harsher slopes and stony ribs of earth, and the peaks rise like sentinels that have watched too many winters to care who wins the next one.

But quiet does not mean safety.

This region is known for what roams beyond sight, dangerous creatures that claim the ridgelines and treelines when the light fades. And there is one name people speak with careful mouths: the Nightmares. Humanoid figures said to haunt this place like a lingering curse. Lately they've been strangely passive—keeping their distance for months—but their absence never feels like mercy. It feels like waiting.

A figure moves through that waiting.

Alaric Branwood slips between pines and rock in a dark brown cloak, hood low against the drifting snow. Hazle-brown hair escapes in the wind, and his purple eyes lift often—searching the high ground, the shadows between trunks, the places where a predator would choose to stand. He pauses once, listening, letting the silence answer him. Not fearlessness—practice. He's encountered enough of this land's ugliness to know you don't walk it without respect.

Only when the quiet holds does he continue.

His skin looks almost soft against the severity of the mountains, but his clothes tell the truth of him: the dark blue sleeves worn at the cuffs, brown trousers dusted with trail grit, and winter shoes whose light-brown fur tops are matted from years of use. The leather is scuffed and creased, shaped by countless hills and roads. These boots have walked too far to pretend they're new.

He leans on a long staff as he climbs, taking his time. The ache in his lower back is a constant companion, dull most days, sharp on climbs like this, so every step is measured, every shift of weight deliberate. Since morning he's been walking from the hut, following paths only he seems to notice, until the land rises into rocky shelves and narrow ledges that look down over misty valleys.

This is a region where the rare herbs grow.

And rare means valuable—more than coin, in wartime.

But today, Alaric has not come for coin.

He has come because Itha's fever has worsened.

Since the last moonrise, her skin had burned too hot beneath his hand, her breath thin and uneven beneath the blankets. The herbs he kept dried above the hearth had helped for a time, enough to draw the worst heat from her body and let her sleep, but the bundle had not lasted.

Before he left, he had used the last of it.

The final dried roots had gone into the fever tea that morning, crushed between his fingers and stirred into bitter steam while Itha lay too still beneath the blankets. By the time the cup was empty, there was nothing left above the hearth but dust, string, and the faint scent of medicine.

So he climbed.

Near a cliff face, the sound of water threads through the cold: a small waterfall spilling down the mountain in thin, silver strands, carving dark wet streaks into the stone before disappearing into snow below. Spray clings to the rock and freezes at the edges, and in that constant damp—where the mountain breathes water and ice at once—the flowers grow.

Alaric sees them from the lower plateau.

Frostheart Edelweiss.

Alaric exhales, relief almost weakening him.

“There you are,” he murmurs.

The plants grow higher than he hoped, tucked into a narrow ledge where the waterfall keeps the stone damp and treacherous. He looks at the climb, then down at the staff in his hand.

For a moment, he almost laughs.

“Wait here,” he tells it quietly, as if the old wood might object.

He leans the staff against the rock wall, making sure it won’t slide away, then sets both hands to the cold stone and begins to climb.

The first few holds come easily enough. His fingers find cracks in the rock, his boots scrape for purchase, and slowly he pulls himself upward toward the next plateau. Snow dusts his sleeves. Meltwater runs beneath his palms. The ledge is close now, close enough that he can see the yellow freckles at the heart of each Frostheart bloom.

Then his foot slips.

For one sickening instant, his weight drops.

Alaric reacts before fear can fully form. One hand snaps upward and catches a jagged edge of stone while his other arm braces hard against the cliff. His boot scrapes over ice, searching, searching, until it finds a narrow ridge barely wide enough to hold him.

Pain strikes through his lower back.

Sharp. White. Punishing.

“Ahh—my back...” His breath catches between his teeth. “Not now.”

He stays there, pressed to the rock, eyes shut tight while the pain claws through him. One bad movement. That is all it ever takes. One twist too far, one slip, one desperate reach, and the old ache wakes like something angry.

But Itha needs this.

So he breathes through it.

Slowly, carefully, he pulls himself onto the higher plateau.

The last stretch takes almost everything from him. His fingers hook over the icy edge, nails scraping stone through his gloves, and for one breath he hangs there with his boots searching uselessly below. Then he grits his teeth, forces strength into his arms, and drags himself up over the ledge.

He collapses onto the snow-covered stone with a hard exhale.

For a moment, Alaric only lies there.

The cold presses through his cloak. Meltwater continues further to seep into his sleeves. His lower back throbs in deep, angry pulses, each one spreading down through his hips like a warning. He shuts his eyes and breathes through it, one hand pressed against the place where the pain burns worst.

“I am getting to old for this,” he mutters, though the words come out weaker than he likes.

The mountain gives no answer. Only the waterfall murmurs nearby, spilling silver threads over dark stone while snow drifts through the spray.

After a while, the sharpest edge of the pain begins to dull.

Not vanish. It never truly vanishes.

It only retreats far enough to be ignored.

Alaric opens his eyes and turns his head.

And there they are.

The Frostheart Edelweiss grows in clusters along the damp stone, pale blossoms pressed close to the mountain as if trying to hide from the wind. Their white petals are silvered at the edges, soft as winter fur, and beneath them hang tiny red fruits shaped like wild strawberries, bright and full against the snow. More than he expected. More than he dared hope.

For a second, relief warms him so suddenly it almost feels like laughter.

A jackpot.

Not only Frostheart, either. Between the roots and stones, he spots other valuable herbs tucked into the wet cracks of the plateau: thin blue sprigs of moonmint, bitter blackleaf curled beneath frost, and small golden stems of sunmarrow clinging stubbornly to the rock. Good for trade. Good for coin. Good for the lean weeks still waiting ahead.

But not first.

First, Itha.

Always Itha.

Alaric pushes himself upright with a pained breath and settles onto his knees before the Frostheart Edelweiss. From his satchel he takes a narrow digging knife and a square of cloth, worn soft from years of use. He works slowly, gently, loosening the frozen soil around each plant instead of tearing it free.

Flower. Fruit. Root.

All of it useful.

The fruits would give strength to a weakened body. The roots, boiled and crushed properly, could draw fever down from the blood. He needs the whole plant, but not all of them. Never all. Taking everything is how foolish hands turn medicine into memory.

So he chooses carefully.

The strongest plants. The ones with thick roots and full fruit. The ones that can spare being taken. The smaller clusters he leaves untouched, covering their bases again with loose snow and broken earth to shield them from the wind.

“I must be one lucky man,” he murmurs, brushing snow gently around one of the younger plants, careful not to disturb the roots. “Finding so many of you here...”

His voice trails off as he looks beyond the ledge.

From this height, Velldenaar opened before him in pale layers of pine, stone and the icy mist. Soft flakes continue to drift down into the land below, slow and weightless, disappearing into the white valley as if the world were being covered piece by piece.

For a moment, Alaric simply watched.

The view was cold, lonely, and beautiful in a way that made him forget the ache in his back for half a breath. Beyond the cliffs and trees, the land stretched on beneath the snow, quiet enough to almost seem gentle.

Almost.

Alaric let out a tired breath, a small smile touching his mouth despite himself.

“And this view,” he says softly. “This view surely is something.”

Then his eyes fall back to the Frostheart Edelweiss gathered in his cloth, to the red fruits, the pale flowers, the roots still damp with frozen earth.

“With this, I can help Itha even more.”

His knife slips beneath another root.

The motion is careful. Familiar. A quiet thing done with steady hands, the same kind of patience he had used when preparing fever teas, crushing herbs, stirring bitter remedies until the steam rose warm against his face.

And with that thought, his mind drifts back to the hearth.

To the night the fever began.

It had been late, the hut wrapped in darkness except for the soft glow of the fire. Itha stood near the hearth with her back mostly turned to him, sleeves drawn up, long hair falling forward as she worked. She had gone hunting earlier and returned with rabbits, fresh and stiff from the cold, and now she prepared them with practiced ease.

Alaric had watched from the resting place across the room, propped against his blankets, one hand resting near his aching back.

He watched her hands.

Her shoulders.

The way the fire caught in her hair and turned it gold.

And the bandages.

They slipped from the back of her gambeson in pale grey lengths, floating around her like extra limbs. Since Itha had recovered, they had moved with her more and more, answering her thoughts as naturally as fingers answered a hand. At first, Alaric had found them strange. Unsettling, even. But he had told himself she was a conjurer, or something close to it. It would explain the way those wrappings obeyed her, the way they curled around tools, lifted small things, and held them as if they were part of her own body rather than cloth trailing from her back.

Now, in the warmth of the hut, they did not look frightening.

They moved in quiet harmony around her.

One bandage held a wooden spoon in its loose grasp, stirring the pot where vegetables softened in the broth. Another hovered near the herbs, waiting as if it knew exactly when she would need them. The rest drifted behind her in slow, never tangling, never striking, only helping.

So he watched them too.

Sure. Precise. Quiet.

She started stripping the rabbit apart with the kitchen knife, pulling skin from flesh and separating meat from bone in a way that made his stomach twist and his heart ache at the same time. Alaric had never been made for killing. Blood unsettled him. Death lingered too long in his thoughts. He could buy meat from locals when coin allowed it, set poor snares when hunger demanded it, but taking life with his own hands had always felt like something his soul refused to learn.

Itha did not flinch from it.

She took what the world gave them and made it survivable.

And as he watched her in the dim glow of the hearth, Alaric smiled gently, filled with a love so quiet and certain that for a moment he forgot the cold world beyond the walls.

The scent of herbs rose with the steam, mixing with the faint trace of Itha herself: smoke from the hearth, cold air from the hunt, and the quiet warmth that always seemed to linger when she was near.

Then one of her loose bandages drifted away from her.

Alaric noticed it from where he rested, but he did not move. He only watched as the pale strip floated slowly through the warm air between them, soft and weightless in the firelight. It crossed the room without hurry, then settled against his cheek and brushed his face softly, light as careful fingers.

His smile softened.

Alaric lifted his hand and placed it over the bandage, pressing it more firmly against his skin. He closed his eyes halfway, leaning into the touch as if it were her palm instead of cloth.

“I love you too,” he whispered.

The words were barely more than breath, too quiet to cross the room, too soft to reach her over the bubbling pot and the crackle of the fire.

Across the room, Itha did not speak.

She did not need to.

The love was not only his.

It had never been only his.

The bandage lingered there for a few breaths, held beneath his hand, and in that small silence the hut felt impossibly full. Not with words. Not with promises. Only with the soft certainty of being wanted by someone who had once seemed too wounded for the world to reach.

Then the bandage slipped from beneath his fingers and drifted back to her, returning to the quiet rhythm of her movements beside the hearth.

After so many years alone, he still struggled to believe she was real.

Someone beside him.

Someone breathing in the same warmth.

Someone he had helped nourish back from the edge of death, and who now, in her own strange and silent way, nourished him in return. Not only with food, not only with the meat she hunted or the fire she tended, but with presence. With the shape of her moving through the room. With the knowledge that when night settled over the forest, he would not be alone beneath it.

He loved her for that.

For the way her presence made the hut feel less empty.

For the warmth she carried into the room without ever needing to fill it with more than herself.

For the life she had brought into a place he had long ago mistaken for a grave.

For a little while, the hut had almost felt safe.

Alaric closed his eyes, just for a moment, letting himself listen to the soft sounds of the hearth: the crackle of wood, the quiet scrape of her knife, the bubbling of broth as herbs opened their scent into the room.

Then something fell.

A bowl, maybe.

Wood striking floor.

His eyes snapped open.

Itha was no longer standing.

“Itha?”

He was moving before the fear had a name, pushing himself up too quickly, pain flashing through his back as he crossed the room. She had collapsed beside the hearth—or almost collapsed. The pale grey bandages from her back had caught her before she struck the floor, wrapping around her waist and shoulders, holding her half-hovered above the ground while her legs lay slack against the wood.

For one terrible second, Alaric froze.

Then he dropped beside her and gathered her carefully into his arms. The bandages loosened only slightly, still trembling around her as if afraid to let go.

“Itha. Itha, can you hear me?”

Her eyes remained closed. Her face was turned slightly away from him, lashes trembling faintly against fever-warmed skin. One hand pressed weakly against her chest.

“I feel...” Her voice was small, confused, not like her. “Weird.”

Alaric swallowed hard. “Where?”

“My chest,” she whispered. “It hurts. Like something stung me.” Her fingers curled faintly against the fabric. “And my heart feels... wrong.”

The words chilled him more than the wind outside.

He pressed his hand to her forehead.

Heat met him at once.

Too much heat.

Far too much.

His chest tightened.

“You’re burning,” he whispered, though he tried to keep the panic from his voice. “It’s a fever.
A bad one.”

Itha shifted weakly in his arms, dizzy and unsteady, as if even the blanket of his hold was too heavy. The bandages tightened again, careful but firm, keeping her from sinking fully to the floor.

“I was only... cooking.”

“I know.” He pulled her closer, careful, desperate. “I know. Don’t move.”

Her body had gone frighteningly numb in his arms, all the strength drained from it at once. Only the bandages still moved with any certainty, pale grey lengths trembling around her as if they were the last part of her that remembered how to obey.

Alaric lifted her as gently as he could and carried her to the bed. His back screamed at the effort, but he ignored it, lowering her onto the blankets as if one wrong movement might break her further.

“There,” he murmured, brushing damp hair away from her cheek without looking into her eyes. “You’re alright. Everything will be alright.”

Her hand twitched faintly.

Blood stained her fingers from the rabbit she had been preparing.

Alaric fetched a cloth, wet it with warm water from beside the hearth, and returned to her side.

He took her hand in his and began to clean the blood away, slow and careful, wiping between her fingers, beneath her nails, across the lines of her palm.

“You rest now,” he said softly. “I’ll finish the meal and make you some tea for the fever.”

One of the bandages drifted toward him.

For a moment, he thought it meant to take the cloth from his hand. Instead, it curled over his wrist, then settled lightly across the back of his hand, guiding nothing, gripping nothing too tightly—only holding on.

Alaric looked at it.

Then at Itha.

Her eyes remained closed, her breathing thin, her face turned slightly away. She had almost no strength left in her body. Barely enough to speak. Barely enough to keep from trembling.

But still, somehow, enough to reach for him.

Enough to use whatever strange conjurer's gift lived in her bones and touch him through cloth instead of fingers.

His throat tightened.

"I'm here," he whispered. "I'm not going anywhere."

The bandage rested against his hand a moment longer.

Then it loosened, slowly, as if even that small effort had cost her too much.

That was when Alaric looked toward the drying herbs above the hearth and counted them in his mind.

Too few. Far too few.

The memory fades with the cold bite of the mountain returning to his fingers.

Then his gaze shifts to the gathered cloth beside him.

Enough. More than enough.

He wraps the last plant carefully, making sure not to crush the fruit or snap the roots, then ties the cloth tight and places it deep inside his satchel. Around him, the smaller clusters remain untouched, their pale blossoms still clinging to the damp stone, waiting for another season, another need, another desperate climb.

Alaric looks down from the plateau.

The path back waits below, steep and slick with ice. His staff stands where he left it, leaning against the rock wall like an old friend pretending it had not been abandoned. Beyond it, somewhere through snow and stone and thinning forest, the hut waits.

Itha waited.

His face hardened with determination.

The pain in his back was still there, dull and bitter, ready to punish the first careless move. But pain was only pain. It could follow him if it must. It could bite at him all the way home.

He had what he came for.

Now he only had to get back to her.

Alaric tightened the satchel against his side and drew in one cold breath.

“Don’t worry, Itha,” he murmured into the falling snow. “I’m coming home soon.”

Then he lowered himself carefully over the edge and began the climb down.

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Some time later, the mountain stood behind him.

Alaric was back below the higher cliffs, staff in hand, cloak damp at the edges, the gathered herbs tucked safely inside his satchel. The wrapped Frostheart Edelweiss rested deep in the bag, protected beneath cloth and leather, and with every step he felt their weight like a promise.

Around him, the land opened into a maze of water.

Small rivers ran everywhere here, spilling down from the mountain in silver threads before dividing through stone, roots, and snow. Some moved quietly beneath thin sheets of ice. Others hurried over black rocks, bright and restless, all of them looking far too similar when the light turned pale and the forest began to close around them.

Following the wrong one could lead a man half a day from where he meant to go.

Alaric stopped near the riverbank and listened.

Water to his left.

Water to his right.

Water ahead, hidden somewhere beneath ice and stone.

He exhaled through his nose and began searching the trees.

Not for tracks. Not for broken branches.

For red.

A few moments passed before he saw it: a small strip of faded red cloth tied around a narrow pine near one of the river bends. The color had dulled beneath frost and weather, but it still stood out against the black bark.

Alaric's shoulders loosened.

“Found you at last,” he murmured. “My way home.”

He approached the tree and brushed snow from the ribbon with his thumb. The cloth was stiff from cold, but the knot still held. That was the important part. Not the ribbon itself. The knot.

Anyone could mark a tree.

The knot told him how to return.

Alaric turned the cloth carefully until he found where it rested against the bark. Low on the trunk. Angled toward the river bend. Tied on the side he had come from, so when he returned, his hands would remember what his tired eyes might miss.

A small warmth touched his face.

Old Odran had taught him that.

Alaric had been thirteen then, all thin wrists, wary eyes, and clothes hanging too loose from hunger. After King Aren Thornwell gave the order to hunt down witches tied to the Bloodmoon, Alaric had been forced to flee into the forest alone. By the time he reached the trees, he carried little more than fear, grief, and the desperate need to keep moving.

Old Odran had found him there with crying eyes and a body almost hollowed by hunger.

He had taken him in without asking further questions.

Odran had already been old then, with a back bent like a weathered branch and hands so crooked they looked as if every winter had left a mark on them. Yet those hands could tie knots, sort herbs, mend boots, and find north beneath clouded stars.

In the memory, winter light fell through snow-heavy pine needles, pale and quiet, but somehow gentler than the cold around him now.

Old Odran had brought him to a bend in the river that day, where the trees grew close to the bank and the path behind them disappeared too easily beneath snow. Young Alaric stood beside him, watching as the old man took a faded strip of red cloth from his pouch.

“Come here, boy,” Odran said. “If you are going to survive in these woods, you must learn how to find your way back before you learn how to go forward.”

Alaric stepped closer, his boots sinking softly into the snow.

Odran tied the ribbon around a tree with slow, careful hands. His fingers were crooked with age, but they moved with the certainty of someone who had done the same thing a thousand times before.

“Look close.”

“I am looking.”

“No,” Odran said, though there was no cruelty in it. “You are watching my hands. Watch what I am telling the forest.”

Alaric narrowed his eyes at him.

Odran chuckled and pulled the knot tight. “This ribbon tells you that this place matters. The knot tells you how to return from it.”

“Why not just follow the river?” Alaric asked.

Odran glanced at him.

“I mean...” Young Alaric looked toward the water, frowning as if the answer should have been obvious. “We came from that way, didn’t we? We followed the river until here. So if we just follow it back, we get back.”

“Because rivers lie,” Odran said.

Alaric looked at him, then back to the water. “It is just water.”

“Aye. And water is very good at pretending it remembers where it came from.”

Young Alaric did not answer.

Odran rested one hand on the tree, beside the strip of red cloth. “Listen to me. Some places are kind. A hill stays where you left it. A stream keeps its bed. A stone waits where it fell. But Velldenar is not always kind, and it is not always still.”

Alaric's gaze moved uneasily between the trees. "The land moves?"

"Sometimes only in your head," Odran said. "Fog comes down. Snow covers the banks. Fear makes three paths look true at once. But sometimes the ground itself changes. A bank breaks. A stone sinks. A slope shifts in the night, and by morning the way you trusted no longer looks like the way home."

He tapped the knot with one bent finger.

"That is why you leave yourself something honest."

Alaric looked at the ribbon again.

"A ribbon tied by your own hand, with the knot resting toward home, is a promise you made before the land had time to confuse you. When you return, do not trust the river first. Do not trust your fear first. Find the knot. Let it remind you where your feet meant to go."

"So the knot points home?"

"Not points," Odran said. "Rests. You tie it on the side you need to return by. A pointing thing can trick the eye. A resting thing waits for the hand."

He took Alaric's fingers gently and guided them over the knot, making him feel the way the cloth sat against the bark.

"Feel that?"

Alaric nodded.

"Good. Your eyes may fail you in snow. Your head may fail you in fear. Your hand is harder to fool."

Young Alaric studied the knot more seriously now. "And if someone else finds it?"

"Then you tied it badly."

Alaric looked at him.

Odran's mouth twitched. "The trick is not only to leave a mark. The trick is to leave one meant for you, not for every fool, beast, and hungry thing wandering through the trees."

He tucked the ribbon slightly beneath a strip of loose bark, leaving only a small edge visible from the right angle.

“Old cloth,” he said. “Faded cloth. Dirtied cloth. Something that does not shout unless you already know it is speaking.”

Alaric leaned closer, and only then did he see how easily the ribbon almost vanished against bark and shadow.

“See?” Odran said. “A stranger walks past and sees nothing. A beast sees nothing. But you come back looking for it, and there it is.”

Young Alaric touched the small edge of red. “And when I no longer need it?”

“Then you take it with you.”

“Why?”

“Because a path left behind can be used by more than the one who made it.” Odran’s voice softened, but his eyes stayed serious. “Never leave a way home open unless you are willing for something else to learn it.”

Alaric was quiet for a moment, then sighed through his nose. “That seems like a lot of work for a piece of cloth.”

Odran looked at him from beneath wild grey brows.

Then he smiled, slow and tooth-worn.

“Living is often a lot of work.”

The memory faded with the cold river murmuring beside him.

Alaric stood once more in the snow, older now, though not old enough to stop hearing Odran’s voice whenever his fingers touched a knot.

His smile lingered.

“Still a lot of work,” he muttered.

Then, quieter, with a warmth that ached more than it comforted, he added, “I truly miss you, old friend.”

The words left him softly and vanished into the cold.

He untied the ribbon slowly, carefully, working the stiff cloth loose from the bark before folding it into his palm. He did not leave markers behind once they had served their purpose.

He tucked the red cloth into his satchel beside the wrapped Frostheart Edelweiss and moved on.

The river stayed close to his right for a while, then curved away through a patch of black stone and low firs. Before long, he found another ribbon. Then another. One by one, he gathered them as he made his way back toward the hut, each strip of red cloth appearing exactly where he had tied it earlier that day, before the climb had taken him higher into the mountain. They waited at bends, crossings, and the places where the land most liked to pretend all directions were equal.

Each time, before he touched the knot, Alaric paused and looked around.

He searched the snow for signs that he had not been the only one to pass this way. Human tracks. Animal prints. The deeper gouge of something heavier, stranger, less natural. He studied the riverbanks, the roots, the places beneath overhanging stone where a beast might have crouched or a traveler might have rested. He looked for broken branches, dragged marks, any hint that the path had been shared.

He found none.

No fresh steps.

No spoor.

No claw marks breaking the frost.

Nothing.

That should have eased him.

In a small way, it did.

His shoulders loosened a little more with every clear stretch of ground. If anything had crossed here ahead of him, the snow had hidden it well enough to be forgotten. And perhaps that was mercy. Perhaps this time, the path home would remain only his.

Then, while untying another ribbon near a low stand of pines, he heard it.

A sound so faint he almost mistook it for the wind.

Alaric stilled.

The cloth remained looped around his fingers as he listened.

There it was again.

A sniff.

Then something like crying.

No—softer than crying. Stranger. Weeping.

The sound drifted thinly through the whiteness, distant enough to be uncertain, but real enough to make the fine hairs at the back of his neck rise. He turned slowly, scanning the trees, the river, the long pale slopes between them.

Nothing moved.

Snow lay over everything in dull, unbroken quiet. White over stone. White over root. White over old deadfall. No figure bent in pain. No traveler collapsed by the bank. No wounded hunter dragging themselves toward shelter.

Only the river. Only the trees. Only the sound, fading almost as soon as he turned his head toward it.

Alaric frowned.

For a moment, he stood there listening harder, as if the world might repeat itself more clearly if he wanted it enough. But the sound did not come again. Not at once.

He shook his head and untied the ribbon free.

“Odd,” he murmured to himself. “Must have been the river.”

Yet even as he said it, the excuse felt thin.

He tucked the ribbon into his bag, then gave the trees a wary glance.

“Odran forgot to mention that Velldenaar speaks too,” he muttered. “Now even the river sounds like a voice.”

The words were meant to make the thought smaller. Less dangerous. Something foolish enough to leave behind.

So he hurried on, but his eyes had grown sharper now. They moved constantly between the trees, the snow, and the riverbank, searching for anything that might explain what he had heard.

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The land sloped gradually downward after that, narrowing into a rocky pass where the trees thinned and the river cut deeper into the earth. Alaric knew this part of the path well. Farther ahead, the valley would split open into a long drop, and the narrow rope bridge would carry him across to the other side.

The hut was not far beyond that bridge.

Once he crossed it, he would know the rest of the way home without ribbons or knots. The land could twist its rivers and dress its trees in snow all it wanted; after the bridge, the path became familiar enough for his feet to remember.

He had used the crossing many times: the bend in the river, the black stones near the edge, the old posts driven into frozen ground where rope and wood held one side of the cliff to the other. Soon, the trees would thin enough for him to see it.

Instead, he heard the weeping again.

It came from somewhere ahead, stronger than before, low and broken beneath the wind. This time there was no mistaking it for river-water or ice. It was a man's voice, crying somewhere near the bridge, wounded or afraid, the sound breaking again and again into something too weak to become a proper call for help.

Alaric stopped before the path fully opened.

His fingers tightened around his staff.

He knew that voice.

The realization moved through him cold and sudden. He had heard it before, almost three months ago, carried through snow and trees, urging him onward until it led him to Itha.

But it had not wept then.

Back then, the voice had been urgent, almost desperate to be followed, as if something unseen had needed him to find her before it was too late.

Now it sounded broken.

Frightened.

As if death itself had a hand around its throat.

Alaric's chest tightened. If this was the same voice that had brought him to Itha, then perhaps it was leading him again. Perhaps there was another person near the bridge who needed him. A traveler. A hunter. Someone hurt and unable to call properly.

Or perhaps the man behind the voice was the one who needed saving.

Perhaps even one of the Bloodmoon warriors, or a soldier of Kalluth caught too far from his own.

Alaric hoped it was neither.

He did not wish to encounter warriors from either side. Not here. Not alone. Not while Itha waited for him.

But that voice had brought him to her once.

To Itha.

To the woman he loved.

And if it was crying now, if someone was suffering near the bridge, then he could not ignore it.

Whatever fear tightened inside him, it was not enough to make him turn away from a man begging to be found.

He quickened his steps, staff biting harder into the snow as he moved toward the opening in the trees.

The weeping continued ahead of him.

He knew better than to raise his voice in a place like this. Old Odran had taught him that too: never give your voice to the forest unless you are ready to face what answers.

Still, Alaric tightened his grip around the staff and looked toward the path ahead.

“Hello?” he called softly. “Can you hear me?”

His voice carried farther than he wanted it to, slipping between the trees and over the snow toward the unseen crossing ahead, and the moment it left him, regret tightened cold around his ribs.

He stopped and listened.

No answer came.

Only the weeping.

Alaric waited a little longer, breath held, but nothing changed. No voice called back. No man answered from the rocks. No wounded traveler begged him to come closer.

The weeping went on, loud enough to be near and yet impossible to place exactly, as if it had not heard him at all.

Unease crawled beneath his skin.

“Where are you?” he called again, louder this time. “Are you hurt?”

Again, nothing answered him. No plea. No warning. Only that same weeping, too familiar to ignore and too broken to understand.

Alaric swallowed hard, then forced himself onward. The bridge was close now. He could feel the land beginning to open ahead, the trees thinning where the path dipped down over the last low shelf of rock before the crossing. He moved toward it carefully, courage and fear pulling at him in equal measure.

Then he reached the edge of the clearing and saw the shape before the bridge.

Tall, black, and motionless.

His body understood danger before his mind could shape it into thought. Alaric slipped sideways at once, pressing himself behind the nearest tree as snow shook loose from the branches above him and scattered over his hood. He did not move again.

His heart struck hard against his ribs.

For a few breaths, he only stood there with his back against the bark, one hand gripping his staff and the other clutching the front of his shirt beneath the cloak. His fingers twisted into the cloth over his heart as if he could hold the pounding still.

The source of the weeping was here.

Somewhere near the bridge.

Slowly, carefully, Alaric leaned just enough to look from behind the trunk.

His eyes found the shape again.

It had not moved.

A tall figure stood before the bridge on Alaric's side of the cliff, blocking the only way across. It did not stand on the planks yet, but just before them, motionless except for the slow rise and fall of its shoulders. Its back was turned to him, facing the bridge and the far side of the valley, while its head remained lifted toward the pale sky, calm and still, as if the weeping had no power to move it at all.

Had it heard him?

The thought almost stole the air from his lungs. He had called out twice. Softly, yes, but softness meant little in a place where snow carried sound strangely and monsters heard things men did not.

But the creature had not turned.

It had not shifted.

His fear did not ease.

Alaric forced his eyes away from the figure and searched for the man. He looked near the bridge, along the cliff edge, beneath the ropes, beside the black stones half-buried in snow. He looked for a body, a hand, a shape curled in pain, anything that could explain the voice.

There was nothing.

Only the creature. Only the bridge. Only the weeping.

For a moment, Alaric could not breathe.

Then his fear gave the shape a name.

A Nightmare.

The word settled inside him like icy spikes driven beneath his ribs. His hand was already clenched around the cloth over his heart, but the longer he stared at the Nightmare, the tighter his fist became. He did not mean to do it. He barely noticed it happening. The fabric bunched harder beneath his fingers, trapped between his grip and the frantic beating in his chest.

One of the deadliest creatures of the southern region stood between him and home, blocking the path to Itha while someone else wept somewhere nearby, unseen and helpless.

Alaric knew what Nightmares were capable of. Not from tavern stories. Not from frightened whispers traded behind barred doors. He had seen them himself, years ago, while gathering herbs at the wrong time in the forest.

The memory did not come all at once.

It crept in slowly at first, through the sound of the weeping and the shape of the thing before the bridge. The pale valley blurred at its edges. The tree beneath his back became another tree. The snow beneath his boots became older snow, stamped down by feet that had not belonged to him.

His hand tightened in his shirt.

He remembered the Redmaw first.

A band of Bloodmoon warriors had been moving through the trees below him, bare-armed and marked for battle, their bodies painted in harsh red patterns against skin hardened by cold, scars, and violence. They wore no armor and carried no weapons. The Redmaw needed none. They fought with their bodies alone, with fists, elbows, knees, teeth, and nails, with savage strength and Bloodmoon trinkets bound to wrists, necks, and ribs, each one meant to answer when battle demanded it. Those trinkets could harden muscle, quicken blood, and force the body past what flesh alone should endure.

Alaric had hidden among the rocks above them and waited for them to pass. He posed no threat to them, and he had no wish to stand in their way, but that did not mean he wanted to be discovered.

So he kept low among the stones, held his breath, and hoped only that they would not see him.

Then the Nightmares came.

Even the Redmaw had not been ready.

Alaric still remembered the first shriek, the way it cut through the trees and sent every bird fleeing from the branches at once. He remembered the warriors turning, bodies lowering into brutal readiness, mouths opening in war cries that became fury, then pain, then something far worse.

They did not run.

The Redmaw were many things, but cowards were not among them. They met the creatures head-on, throwing themselves into the slaughter with fists and teeth and blood-maddened strength. Their trinkets flared against their skin, forcing power into muscle, making broken bodies move when they should have fallen. Even half-dead, they fought. Even with their arms torn open and their blood steaming in the snow, they tried to rise again.

It did not matter.

The Nightmares moved through them as if strength meant nothing.

That was when Alaric had truly seen them.

Tall, stretched things with limbs too long for any living body. Arms hanging near their knees. Legs drawn thin and wrong, carrying them forward with terrible speed. Their skin was black, but not like soot, cloth, or fur. It was deeper than that, like shadow given flesh. Where light touched them, dark red bled across their bodies, a hidden crimson sheen that made them look as if old blood lived beneath the surface.

Their chests and stomachs were hollow.

Not wounded. Empty.

A black absence opened through the center of each Nightmare, where ribs and organs and the protected shape of life should have been. From those voids, black bandages spilled outward, drifting through the air like cloth given hunger.

They reminded Alaric, horribly, of Itha's bandages only in shape.

Nothing more.

Hers came from her back and moved with a strange, quiet gentleness, as if they had learned restraint from the woman they belonged to. These came from emptiness. From the hollow places where life should have been. They did not drift to help. They did not reach with care.

They searched.

They pierced flesh.

They bound what remained.

Alaric's grip tightened as the memory pressed itself onto his mind, forcing him to witness again what mortal eyes should never have been made to see.

He watched one Redmaw warrior have the flesh stripped from his side beneath those blade-like nails. Before the man could fall, the Nightmare seized him with both hands and held him upright, its claws digging into wounded flesh as it forced him backward toward the nearest tree.

The warrior fought against it.

It did not matter.

His back struck the bark, and the Nightmare pressed him there, pinning him in place as the bandages surged from the hollow black absence of its chest and stomach.

They wrapped around him first.

Then they entered him.

The black strips slid into the open wounds like snakes, forcing themselves beneath flesh, muscle, and bone before severing from the Nightmare's hollow shape one by one. Each bandage that broke free remained alive in its own terrible way, binding him tighter to the tree behind him.

His hands clawed at the air.

The bandages sank deeper, threading through his body and into the wood, until flesh, bark, and black cloth began to merge together. It was not simply holding him there. It was making him part of the tree, sealing him into it as if the forest had opened itself to keep him forever.

A strip forced itself between his teeth and slid deep into his mouth. His jaw strained around it, his throat working helplessly, but the scream never came out. Only the shape of agony remained, trapped behind eyes wide with terror.

Then more bandages moved beneath his face.

Alaric watched them rise from inside him, pressing upward behind the eyes until the sockets bulged. The warrior's body shook against the tree, still trying to scream around the strip buried in his mouth, while wet pressure built beneath his face.

Then his eyes came free.

They were pushed out slowly, forced from their sockets by the black cloth moving underneath, left hanging in the cold air beside his face as the bandages drifted softly around them, almost gentle in the way they moved.

Alaric nearly vomited.

His stomach clenched so violently that he had to bite down on his own breath to keep from making a sound. Every part of him wanted to look away.

But he could not.

The warrior was still alive.

His body strained against the tree, his throat working around the bandage buried deep in his mouth, but no scream could escape him. The bark held his back. The black cloth held everything else.

And there he remained, bound alive into wood and bandage, fixed in place by the Nightmare as if even death had been denied the mercy of taking him.

Another Redmaw was taken the same way.

Then another.

The slaughter had not ended. It was still unfolding below him in screams, blood, and frantic movement, the Redmaw fighting even as the Nightmares tore through them. Some bodies already lay opened in the snow, granted the small mercy of stillness. Others remained against the trees, caught in bark and black cloth, some silent forever and some still twitching weakly where the bandages held them.

Living and dead together.

Horror rooted into wood.

Alaric's breath thinned behind his teeth.

The bridge before him was still there. The real snow was still cold around his boots. The Nightmare before the crossing still had its back turned to him, its head lifted toward the pale sky.

But as Alaric stared at the back of its head, the shape in front of him blurred with the one from the memory.

For one terrible breath, he no longer saw only the creature at the bridge.

He saw the other one.

The one that had turned.

The one that had found him.

Its face had been almost human only in the cruelest sense, stretched into something angular and wrong. Its eyes were pale voids, lost in light, but inside each one burned a red iris like a coal buried in ash.

And that red stare found him.

The memory struck so hard that every hair on Alaric's body rose beneath his clothes. His eyes widened before he could stop them, then shut tightly as if darkness alone could keep the memory out. A cold sweat began to gather along his throat as the old terror opened inside him, as if no years had passed at all.

He had run.

Despite the pain in his lower back, he swallowed it whole and ran. Fear left no room for aching bones or tired muscles. He ran like a terrified animal, crashing through branches, slipping over snow, tearing his cloak on thorns and jagged rock while the Nightmare came after him.

He dropped his staff somewhere in the panic. Not by choice. Not knowingly. One moment it was in his hand, the next it was gone, lost behind him as he stumbled forward with empty fingers and a heart beating so hard it felt as if it might tear itself loose.

But that evening, he only ran.

He remembered the sound behind him. Not breath. Not truly. Something hollow and wrong from a body that should not have been alive. He remembered branches snapping too close, snow breaking under something far faster than him, and then the violent pull at his satchel when claws caught the leather strap across his back.

For one heartbeat, it had him.

The only thing that saved him was the small knife at his belt and panic sharp enough to guide his hand. He cut the strap loose while the Nightmare held on to the bag, and the sudden release sent him stumbling backward over the edge of the slope. He did not fall far. Not truly. He slid hard through snow, mud, loose stones, and frozen roots, rolling just enough for the world to blur before his body struck the lower ground with the breath knocked from his chest.

For a moment, he could only lie there, gasping.

Above him, the Nightmare did not follow.

It only stood there with the torn-off bag in its hands, staring down at him with a malice that felt almost patient.

Alaric remembered that most clearly. Not the slide. Not the pain. The watching. The way it remained above him, holding what it had ripped from him, while he forced his shaking body to move.

His clothes were torn and filthy, his arms and side marked with shallow cuts from stone and ice, but he was alive.

He stumbled beneath the trees, half limping, half falling forward, and did not stop until the Nightmare was gone from sight. Even then, he kept moving, with his heart still trying to tear itself free from his chest.

He still carried a few scars from that evening, thin pale marks across his side and shoulder where stone and claw had caught him. Nothing grand. Nothing heroic. Just small reminders left beneath the skin, easy to miss unless the firelight touched them the right way.

The memory had never truly left him.

And now one stood before him again.

Not in memory.

Not in the old snow of years past, not above some distant slope with his torn bag in its hands, watching him crawl away.

It stood before the bridge now, unmoving, while the weeping of a man he could not find filled the cold air between them.

And beyond it lay the path home.

The path to Itha.

She was waiting there with fever burning through her body, and every moment he remained trapped on this side of the bridge was another moment stolen from her.

#

Moments passed without anything happening.

Alaric stayed pressed against the tree, one hand still clutching the front of his shirt beneath the cloak. His fingers held the cloth over his heart as his breathing slowly, painfully, came back under his control. Not calm. Not truly. Calm felt too far away for that. But enough to think. Enough to force the panic down before it made him do something foolish.

Going around was not truly a choice. His throat remained tight with fear as he thought of the other ways through the cliffs, old hunter paths and crueler slopes that wound through broken stone and frozen ravines, but none of them were safe.

Some would force him deeper toward Bloodmoon territory, where even his own blood would not keep him safe if the wrong eyes found him. Others would lead him through paths already swallowed by war, places watched, crossed, and claimed by men who would see only what side he might belong to before deciding what to do with him.

What should have been a walk of less than half an hour would become days. Days of climbing, backtracking, searching for safe ground, slipping past danger with no promise that he would succeed.

No promise that he would even reach the hut at all.

Itha did not have days.

The herbs in his satchel pressed against his side as if reminding him of that. They were useless here. Useless in the snow. Useless unless he brought them home while there was still breath in her body.

His hand shifted toward the satchel without thinking.

The last time a Nightmare had found him, it had taken his bag from him. Back then, it had been a delivery for Solomon, something lost, something ruined, something he could live with losing. It had frightened him. It had cost him. But it had not held a life inside it.

This time was different.

If the creature took this satchel, if those claws tore it from him again, then the herbs would be gone. Itha's chance would be gone with them.

Alaric swallowed hard.

He could not go around.

He could not charge ahead.

And he could not let the Nightmare take from him twice.

But there was also the weeping voice.

Somewhere near the bridge, or beneath it, or beyond the place his eyes could reach, someone was crying. Someone might be hurt. Someone might be trapped close enough to hear and too broken to answer. Alaric could not leave him if there was a way to help.

So he kept watching.

He searched for anything that might give him an answer: a twitch of the Nightmare's shoulders, a turn of its lifted head, a change in the slow drift of the bandages spilling from the hollow of its body. Some sign that it knew he was there. Some sign that the weeping belonged to something he could still save.

The weeping continued without pause.

Minutes passed.

Then more.

Nothing changed.

The Nightmare did not move from the bridge. The crying did not weaken. The man did not answer. No hand appeared from beneath the planks. No body dragged itself from behind the stones. No voice called to him with words.

Only the weeping.

Alaric stared at the creature and felt a colder doubt settle inside him.

“That cannot be a dying man,” he whispered.

The words barely left his mouth.

The weeping went on, steady and broken, filled with suffering, filled with fear, but too unchanged. Too constant. No one in pain wept like that for so long without gasping, begging, coughing, breaking into words, or falling silent from exhaustion.

It sounded human.

It sounded helpless.

But the longer Alaric listened, the harder it became to believe that it belonged to a man at all.

His gaze dropped to the snow near his boots.

A few stones lay half-buried beside the tree roots.

For a moment, he only looked at them.

Then his eyes shifted toward the trees away from the bridge.

“If I throw one far enough,” he murmured, “maybe I can draw it away.”

His voice trembled despite how softly he spoke.

He crouched slowly, keeping the trunk between himself and the Nightmare, and reached toward one of the stones. His gloved hand hovered above it.

Then stopped.

What if it heard?

What if the sound did not lead it away, but woke whatever attention it had not yet given him?

What if it turned toward the stone, then toward the place the stone had come from? What if this one foolish act did not save him, did not save the crying man, did not save Itha, but doomed them all at once?

Fear gripped his heart so hard that he felt it pound again beneath the cloth of his shirt.

His hand shook above the stone.

He did not know what to do.

Then the weeping changed.

It rose sharply, twisting into something thin and terrible, a sound caught between a shriek and the familiar male voice he knew. It tore through the trees with such sudden force that birds burst from the branches around the clearing, wings beating wildly into the pale sky as if the forest itself had been startled awake.

“Alaric.”

His body froze.

The stone remained untouched beneath his hovering hand.

His eyes widened.

For one breath, he could not even understand what had happened. The sound still seemed to hang in the air around him, trembling between the trees, too impossible to belong to anything real.

“Did I just hear my name?” he whispered.

Then the terror came back.

Not slowly.

All at once.

The shock went through him so violently that the space between his fingers and the stone suddenly felt impossible to cross. His heart struck hard against his ribs, heavy and violent, and all strength drained from his arm. Slowly, Alaric lowered himself back against the trunk, his eyes wide, his breath trapped in his throat.

Had he imagined it?

He wanted to believe he had.

But the birds were still fleeing.

Their cries scattered through the trees above him, fading into the cold distance.

Slowly, with all the courage his shaking body could gather, Alaric turned his head toward the bridge.

The Nightmare had moved.

Not its body.

Its body still faced the bridge, still pointed toward the far side of the valley.

Only the head had turned.

Its neck had twisted back toward him in a way no living neck should bend, the face now staring over its own shoulder while the rest of the creature remained motionless before the crossing.

Alaric could not move.

Those eyes found him.

The same red.

The same stare.

The same terror from the memory, dragged back into the present as if no years had passed at all.

His heart pounded so hard it seemed to shake the inside of his chest.

It found him.

It found him again.

Small tears slipped down Alaric's face before he even felt them gather, forced from him by the body's own helpless reaction. He gave no sob, no sound, no movement large enough to betray him further. Only the tears came, warm against his frozen skin, drawn out by a fear too old and too deep to command.

The Nightmare did not come for him.

It only stared.

For a few seconds, nothing existed except the space between them. Alaric looked at the creature through a vision blurred by fear and tears, and that was when he saw the black ichor gathering beneath its hollow eyes.

It seeped slowly from the sockets, thick and dark, trailing down its face and over its chest before dripping softly into the snow below.

Like tears.

Even through the terror, the thought reached him.

Was it weeping?

Then the Nightmare opened its mouth.

A dry, cracking sound followed, like bones breaking one by one beneath skin.

“Alaric.”

His name came again, dragged through that unnatural voice, half shriek, half sob, broken by something that sounded too afraid to be alive.

Alaric’s lips parted.

“How do you—”

The creature lifted its right hand.

Alaric stopped breathing.

Slowly, the Nightmare pointed past itself. Not toward him. Not toward the trees. Toward the bridge, toward the path beyond it, toward whatever waited on the other side.

When it spoke again, the voice scraped through the air like something forced out of a ruined throat.

“Hurry. Return Home.”

A pause.

Another sound of bone shifting.

“The maggots are coming.”

The words struck him harder than the sound of his own name.

Alaric stared at the creature, unable to move, unable to understand. The voice was still broken, still weeping, still filled with that desperate fear that had pulled him through the snow once before.

“Please,” it whispered.

The black ichor continued to run from the Nightmare’s empty eyes, sliding down its face like rotten tears.

“The maggots are coming.”

Alaric could not believe what he was hearing.

This thing had found him once before. It had hunted him through the snow, torn the satchel from his back, and watched him crawl away with patient malice. In his memory, it had never been anything but hunger, cruelty, and death given shape.

And now it was begging him.

Not chasing him.

Not tearing into him.

Begging him to return home.

Home.

Why home?

The thought barely formed before something cold dropped through him.

Not fear of the Nightmare.

Something worse.

“Itha,” he breathed.

Her name left him before he could stop it, small and broken in the frozen air.

The Nightmare did not answer.

It did not lower its hand. It did not step aside. It only remained where it stood, one long arm pointing toward the bridge, toward the path beyond it, toward the hut hidden somewhere past the trees.

Toward her.

Alaric’s throat tightened until it hurt. The same voice had led him to Itha once before, through snow and darkness, when he had not understood what he was following. Now it called to him again, through the mouth of a Nightmare, through weeping and broken bone, and no matter how impossible it was, he could not shake the feeling that something terrible had happened.

Something was wrong at home.

Something was wrong with Itha.

Slowly, Alaric pushed himself away from the tree.

His legs almost failed him.

The Nightmare watched.

It did not move as he stepped from behind the trunk. It did not lunge. It did not reach for him with claws or bandages. Only its head remained twisted back, those red eyes fixed on him while black tears continued to fall from the hollow sockets.

The weeping returned.

Softer at first.

Then deeper.

More devastating than before.

Alaric took one step toward the bridge, then another. Each movement felt like walking into the mouth of something that had only chosen, for reasons he could not understand, not to close its teeth yet. His hand tightened around his staff until his fingers ached. The satchel brushed against his side with every breath, and the herbs inside seemed heavier now than stone.

The Nightmare still did not move.

Even when Alaric came closer.

Even when he passed near enough to see the dark red sheen beneath its black skin, near enough to smell cold rot and old blood, near enough to hear the faint wet sound of ichor dripping into the snow.

Its body remained facing the bridge.

Only its head followed him.

Twisted back over its shoulder.

Watching.

Weeping.

Alaric did not look away. He could not. His fear screamed at him to run, to turn back, to throw himself into the trees and never come near this place again.

But the fear for Itha was greater.

So he passed the Nightmare.

Step by step.

Breath by breath.

When his boot touched the first wooden plank of the bridge, the rope creaked beneath his hand. Alaric gripped it tightly and forced himself forward, the drop yawning below, the wind cutting across the narrow crossing, the Nightmare still behind him with its head turned impossibly toward his back.

He did not know if it would follow.

He did not know if it would let him reach the other side.

The farther he walked onto the bridge, the more the worry inside him rose, swelling until it drowned out the cold, the height, the weeping, and the monster behind him.

Only one thought remained.

Itha.